

Odon Ineza

Prof. Ashley Etter

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Build your Own Empire: How Isaac used Rhetoric to Persuade Me into Thinking about  
Business.

**Introduction**

After interviewing Isaac Basominger the founder and CEO of Kigali Preparatory Center, many questions about freedom, independence, and fulfillment have been amplified in the audience. Not because they don't have clear goals in life, but because Isaac's use of rhetoric was strong enough to make the audience take a pause and rethink. Isaac's story shows that true freedom and fulfillment comes not from following society's traditional paths or chasing monetary success, but from pursuing work that reflects one's values and creates change for others. Using clear examples and strong language backed by facts, Isaac's logos persuaded the audience to think about finding initiative; his ethos also clarified that results of a work should never be defined by monetary benefits but by the impact it leaves on other people's lives.

Isaac's rhetorical focus on credibility, evidence of actual success, and emotional connection convince the audience that pursuing purpose over profit leads to authentic fulfillment and redefines the definition of success.

## Summary

In the interview Isaac Basomingera, **the writer**, describes the story of founding the Kigali Preparatory Center after leaving behind a comfortable corporate job at Bralirwa in pursuit of a more purposeful and rewarding course of life. Asked what drove him to leave his employment, Isaac explained that, though offering him stability, recognition, and the possibility of rising through the corporate ladder, it never provided him with fulfillment. He emphasized that true happiness resulted from the creation of something from scratch and bringing it on a course of life, which would positively affect other lives. Freedom for Isaac meant creating an institution, which would open up possibilities for young Rwandese, especially those of low income backgrounds.

Isaac narrates testimonies of students whose lives were transformed through the center's programs. Isaac shares his story with Odon, **the audience**, in an interview shaped by their shared past mentor-mentee relationship, **the context**; This personal familiarity allows the dialogue to seamlessly build together reflections and instances of coaching and encouragement within the framework of their relationship. The writer's goal, **purpose**, is not only to teach Odon lessons of his life, but to illustrate the larger mission of Kigali Preparatory Center, in describing through the sharing of his own story, **the issue**, ways of finding personal fulfillment by putting passion over profit, while at the same time opening doors of success for others to follow. His story, in its culmination, shows success measured not by personal profit, but by the lives impacted and opportunities granted to the next generation.

## The Rhetorical Appeals

In the interview, even though Isaac doesn't directly get instructed to use rhetorical appeals, in describing his ideas, he deliberately chooses words and phrasings that aim to persuade the audience by using ethos, logos, and pathos. The three rhetorical appeals appear multiple times throughout the interview and they serve to make Isaac's argument better. By breaking down the logical appeals, we notice that even by intertwining more than one appeal, Isaac manages to capture the audience's attention.

### **Ethos**

When he chooses to communicate more about his job and the lens through which he views his work, it gives the audience a full sense of credibility. For instance, when he says, *"I see the world from a different angle for at least a moment. It keeps me humble and reminds me that real leadership is not always having all the answers — it is always being willing to learn among others,"* or, *"Every time that I tutor in SAT math or work with someone to prepare their essays, I see the world from a different angle for at least a moment. It keeps me humble and reminds me that real leadership is not always having all the answers — it is always being willing to learn among others,"* or even, *"As I work with the students and observe how they solve problems, I learn immensely. Each student's mind works differently,"* he demonstrates humility and a willingness to approach his work as a lesson. By showing the perspective through which he views his work, he establishes verity and credibility, sharing a glimpse into his reflections and mindset. This ethos makes the interviewer believe the story Isaac is telling, and that trust serves as ground for persuasion when Isaac later makes his argument.

His pride in his achievements also comes through to show the success he talks about as a result of following his purpose without directly thinking of the profit side of his work, as in the phrase, *"Back in corporate, success was quantified by sales volume, percentage of profits, and the constant ticking of calendars. It is something different here. Here, success is measured by*

*growth—not only that of the learners, but of me as well.*” By presenting a new metric for success, he powerfully shows fulfillment as the reward of forging his own path. This helps the audience easily picture the success of the strategy Isaac is laying out.

### **Logos**

At the core of the essay, Isaac uses proof of success by referencing the current accomplishments of Kigali Preparatory Center. For example, he says, *“Nowadays, the Kigali Preparatory Center has successfully sent graduates to some of the world's top universities—Brown, Notre Dame, Harvard, and Yale.”* This fact-based statement enhances his logos appeal, showing that following his passion led to tangible achievements.

Also, when he describes the challenges of the early days of his organization, he frames them as struggles anyone might face. For instance, he notes, *“Parents were skeptical. Some would say, ‘Why waste money? My child cannot possibly get into Harvard or Yale.’ Others doubted we could sustain the vision. But with every success story the skepticism faded. Results speak louder than promises.”* This example blends logos and pathos: it conveys logical reasoning (results validate the mission) while also evoking empathy for the difficulties he endured. This serves to make his argument better since the facts in this statement help him establish an emotional thread with the interviewer.

He also references specific students he has worked with, such as Kenza Davina and Kenny. By connecting real individuals to outcomes, he appeals to logic with concrete evidence. Statements like these simultaneously strengthen ethos, by showing credibility, and logos, by grounding his work in measurable impact.

### **Pathos**

One of the tools Isaac uses in the interview to tell his story is pathos, by appealing to the emotions of his audience he connects his story to his mission and his description of his work, which eventually adds up to persuade his audience. Reflecting on one of his students, he says, *“My mind goes back to Kenza Davina, at Brown now... When she received the acceptance, she called me in tears of happiness.”* Here, his description of “tears of happiness” evokes an emotional response and highlights the human dimension of his work. Similarly, he explains, *“I counted it by the difference I was making, the smile of the student coming to realize that studying overseas was possible. That was my real wealth.”* In this statement, he equates joy and impact with wealth, shaping his narrative around fulfillment through service to others.

Additionally, when he talks about his shift from a corporate job to starting his own business, he vividly shares his struggles, helping the audience empathize with him and understand the situation. For example, he recalls, *“I jumped in and started from scratch: a humble rented office, borrowed furniture, and limited students. Other people viewed my actions as reckless, even irresponsible.”* This creates an empathetic atmosphere where he communicates the importance of his decision despite its challenges.

## **Conclusion**

The questions raised at the beginning—about free will and fulfillment—become clearer through Isaac’s thoughtful use of rhetoric. His ethos makes him a reliable narrator ready to forego comfort for purpose, his logos positions his story in tangible achievements and outcomes, and his pathos allows the reader to sense the human cost of his mission. These rhetorical choices do more than retell his life; they make the reader rethink how they define success and significance in their own life. Ultimately, Isaac uses rhetoric as not only a tool to persuade, but one made to bring together fulfillment and purpose.

**Work Cited**

Besomingera, Isaac. Personal interview. Monday, 1, September 2025.